

Lewiston Elks Lodge

Newsletter Builder

A Step-by-Step Guide

For the office — everything you need to build and print the lodge newsletter

Elks Care — Elks Share

What this is

The Newsletter Builder lets you put together the lodge's printed newsletter by dragging ready-made blocks onto a page — a lot like building an email. Many blocks fill themselves in **automatically** from lodge records (new members, volunteer hours, the calendar, and so on), so you type very little. When you're done, you print it or save a PDF.

The one big idea: almost every block fills in when you Preview or Print. In the editor those blocks show a grey "Auto-fills when you Print / Preview" note — that's normal. Use the **Preview (data)** button to see the real information at any time.

Quick start — a newsletter in 8 steps

This is the short version. The full guide, with every step and option explained, follows after.

1. **Open the Newsletter app.** Click the apps menu (top-left grid) and choose Newsletter.
2. **Create a new issue.** Click New. Give it a name like "Lodge Newsletter — August 2026."
3. **Set the Issue Date to the newsletter's month.** Use the first day of the month you're publishing (for example Aug 1). This one date drives the masthead month, the volume number, the calendar, and the other monthly blocks.
4. **Pick the Template, then click Load Template.** Choose "Lodge Newsletter" and press the Load Template button. The branded layout — masthead, message, blocks, mailing panel — fills the page.
5. **Write your content.** Click into the Officer's Message and replace the placeholder text. Add or remove blocks from the Blocks tab on the right if you need to.
6. **Check it with Preview (data).** Click Preview (data) at the top. A new tab opens showing the newsletter with all the real information filled in — fast, no waiting.
7. **Print or save a PDF.** Click Print / Download PDF for the final, page-perfect version. Use Preview PDF to see the pages first.
8. **Mark Final when it's done.** Click Mark Final to lock it as the published issue.

Publishing next month early?

Just set the Issue Date to next month. Everything monthly follows it. If you want the calendar or leaderboard to show a **different** month than the issue, each of those blocks has its own "Month shown" setting (see the full guide).

The full guide

1. Opening the app and finding your newsletters

- **Newsletter app:** apps menu (top-left grid) → Newsletter.
- **Newsletters:** the top menu “Newsletters” lists every issue you’ve made. Click one to open it, or click New to start another.
- **Templates:** the “Templates” menu holds the reusable starting layouts. You normally won’t touch this — it’s the master copy each new issue starts from.

2. Creating a new issue

Click **New**. You’ll see a few fields at the top:

- **Name** — the title of this issue, e.g. “Lodge Newsletter — August 2026.” This is just a label for your list.
- **Issue Date** — the most important field. Set it to the first of the month you’re publishing. It drives the masthead month, the “Volume / No.,” and the monthly blocks (calendar, leaderboard, in memoriam, new members).
- **Page Size** — US Letter (8.5 × 11) or US Legal. Letter is the usual choice.
- **Template** — the layout to start from (“Lodge Newsletter”). Pair it with the Load Template button below it — see the next section.
- **Issue Ref / Lodge Name** — these fill in on their own from the lodge settings; you don’t edit them here.
- **Dynamic Block Settings** — a couple of extra choices for the New Members block (which month to pull, and whether to show member photos).

3. Loading the template

A brand-new issue starts from the template automatically. If your page is ever **empty** (it says “Drag building blocks here”), do this:

9. Make sure the Template field shows the layout you want (“Lodge Newsletter”).
10. Click the **Load Template** button just under the Template field.
11. Confirm when it asks. The branded layout fills the page.

Good to know

Load Template **replaces** whatever is on the page, so it asks first. If you’ve already built an issue you like, you don’t need this button. Choosing a template only fills the page by itself when the page is still empty — it will never wipe out work you’ve done.

4. Setting the month for the whole issue

The **Issue Date** is the master switch for the month. Change it and the masthead month, the “Volume 120, No. 8” line, the calendar, the leaderboard and the other monthly blocks all follow.

Tip: if you change the Issue Date and the masthead in the editor still shows the old month, just re-enter the date (type it again) — the masthead updates as soon as the date field changes.

Sometimes you want one block to show a **different** month than the issue — for example, mailing the August issue but showing next month's (September) calendar. The Calendar and the Leaderboard each have their own "Month shown" setting for exactly that; see section 8.

5. Getting around the editor

The newsletter itself is the big white page. On the right is a dark panel with three tabs:

- **Blocks** — the menu of things you can drag onto the page (headers, text, images, and all the "Lodge" blocks). Drag one onto the page to add it.
- **Style** — settings for whatever block you have selected (its width, spacing, and any special options). Click a block on the page first, then open Style.
- **Design** — overall look settings; you'll rarely need this.

Selecting and moving blocks: click a block to select it. A little toolbar appears with icons to move it up, drag it, duplicate it, or delete it (the trash can). To type, click directly into the text.

Page guide lines: as you build, faint dashed lines show where each printed page ends and a light border shows the page margins, so you can tell what fits on a page before you print.

6. Editing the masthead (the banner at the top)

- **Month, website and "Volume / No."** fill in automatically from the Issue Date and lodge settings.
- **The lodge name and "NEWSLETTER" title** are yours to edit — click and type if you ever want to change them.
- **The logo and building photo** come from the lodge settings. If one isn't set, it's simply left off.

7. Writing the Officer's Message

12. Click into the message text and replace it with your own.
13. With the message block selected, open the **Style** tab and use the **Officer** dropdown to choose whose message it is (Exalted Ruler, Leading Knight, and so on).
14. The photo, name and title fill in automatically from that officer when you Preview or Print.

Note: if you change the message's heading yourself, your wording is kept — it won't be overwritten.

8. The auto-fill blocks (and their options)

These blocks show a grey placeholder in the editor and fill with real lodge data when you Preview or Print. Here's what each does; the quick-reference table near the end lists them all together.

Volunteer Hours Leaderboard

- Shows the Elks with the most volunteer hours — two boards, **This Month** and **This Lodge Year** — with the top volunteer featured large and places 2-10 below, plus a note about service.
- **Month shown** — Issue month, Next month, or Last month (or type an exact month like 2026-08).
- **Stack boards** — turn on to place the two boards one above the other (full width) instead of side by side.
- Comes in two versions in the Blocks menu: a normal one you drop into a column, and a **Full Width** one that spans the whole page.

Lodge Calendar

- Shows the month grid with lodge events, matching the website calendar.
- **Month shown** — Issue month, Next month, or Last month (or an exact month). Use this to print next month's calendar when you mail early.

Other auto-fill blocks

- **New Members** — members who joined (controlled by the Dynamic Block Settings up top; optional photos).
- **In Memoriam** — members who passed the month before the issue, now with each member's date of death under their name.
- **Charity Report, Project Dollars, Dues Reminder** — fiscal-year totals and counts from lodge records.
- **Upcoming Events / Events** — approved and published events.
- **Lodge Officers** — the current officer roster.

9. Block options in the Style panel

Select a block, open **Style**, and you may see:

- **Width** — on some blocks, how wide it sits (full, two-thirds, half, one-third) so blocks can sit side by side.
- **Month shown / Exact month** — on the Calendar and Leaderboard (section 8).
- **Pin to page bottom** — drops the block to the bottom of its page when printed — handy for the calendar or the mailing panel.
- **Padding, Border, Background Color** — standard spacing and framing controls.

10. Layout helpers

- **Spacer** — an empty gap you drop in to push what's below it further down the page. Set its height in Style (Small / Medium / Large / Extra Large, or a custom number).
- **Page Break** — forces everything after it onto a new printed page. There's a full-width one (between sections) and an inline one (mid-story).

11. Previewing and printing

- **Preview (data)** — the fast one. Opens a new tab showing the newsletter with all real information filled in, in about a second. Use this constantly while building. Refresh the tab after changes. (It doesn't show exact page breaks — it's for checking the information.)
- **Preview PDF** — the true page-by-page PDF, exactly as it will print (this takes a bit longer to build).
- **Print / Download PDF** — saves/downloads the final PDF to print or email.

12. Marking the issue Final

When the newsletter is done, click **Mark Final** (top of the screen). This marks it as the published issue. You can still Reset to Draft later if you need to make a change.

Quick reference — the Lodge blocks

Everything in the **Blocks** tab under the “Lodge” group. Auto-fill blocks show a grey note in the editor and fill in on Preview / Print.

Block	What it puts in the newsletter	Options (Style panel)
Masthead	The branded banner: month, website, Volume/No., lodge name, logo and building photo.	Text and title editable; month/volume auto-fill from the Issue Date.
Officer's Message	A message with the officer's photo, name and title.	Officer (whose message it is).
Volunteer Leaderboard	Top volunteers this month and this lodge year, #1 featured large.	Month shown; Exact month; Stack boards. Full-width version available.
Lodge Calendar	Month grid of lodge events, like the website.	Month shown; Exact month.
New Members	Members who recently joined.	New Members Source + photos (top of the form).
In Memoriam	Members who passed the prior month, with date of death.	—
Charity Report	Fiscal-year charity totals + a reminder to log hours.	—
Project Dollars	Fiscal-year Project Dollars total.	—
Dues Reminder	Total members and delinquent counts.	—
Upcoming Events / Events	Approved and published events.	—
Lodge Officers	The current officer roster.	Width.
Spacer	An empty vertical gap to push content down.	Height (S/M/L/XL or custom).
Page Break	Forces the next content onto a new page.	Full-width and inline versions.

Tips & troubleshooting

- **The page is empty (“Drag building blocks here”).** Pick the Template, then click Load Template and confirm.
- **The masthead shows the wrong month.** Re-enter the Issue Date (type it again). The masthead updates whenever the date changes.
- **A block still says “Auto-fills...”** That’s normal in the editor. Click Preview (data) to see the real information.
- **The calendar/leaderboard shows the wrong month.** Select that block, open Style, and set “Month shown” (or type an exact month). If both the dropdown and the exact box are set, the exact box wins — clear it to use the dropdown.
- **I want the calendar at the bottom of the page.** Select it, open Style, and turn on Pin to page bottom — or drop a Spacer above it and grow its height.
- **Two blocks won’t sit side by side.** Select each and set its Width in Style (for example, two blocks at Half).
- **It’s taking a long time to preview.** Use Preview (data) for quick checks; save Preview PDF / Print for the final, page-perfect version.
- **Editing works best in Google Chrome.** If the block preview looks stuck in another browser, switch to Chrome.

Need a change to the builder itself? Note what you were doing and pass it to the lodge’s Odoo administrator.